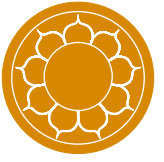
Pema Chödrön's



Compassion Cards

teachings
for awakening the
heart in everyday life



SHAMBHALA | Boulder | 2016

Shambhala Publications, Inc.
4720 Walnut Street
Boulder, Colorado 80301
www.shambhala.com

Instructions and commentary © 2003 by Pema Chödrön
Translations of the slogans from *The Root Text of the Seven Points of Training the Mind* © 1993 by Diana J. Mukpo and the Nalanda Translation Committee

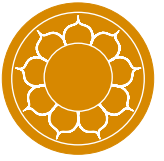
ISBN 978-1-61180-364-8

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Printed in China

Distributed in the United States by Penguin Random House LLC and in Canada by Random House of Canada Ltd

Designed by Liz Quan

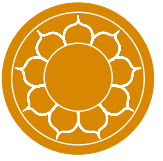


• Training in Loving-Kindness and Compassion

For many years, the fifty-nine slogans that are contained on these cards have been the primary focus of both my personal practice and my teaching. These Tibetan Buddhist slogans (called *lojong*, or "mind-training" teachings) offer pithy, powerful reminders on how to awaken our hearts in the midst of day-to-day life, under any circumstances. They come from an old Tibetan text called *The Root Text of the Seven Points of Training the Mind* by Chekawa Yeshe Dorje. When I first read these slogans, I was struck by their unusual message: We can use everything we encounter in our lives—whether pleasant or painful—to awaken genuine

compassion. These teachings are designed to help ordinary people like ourselves to stand fully in our own shoes and never give up on ourselves. And they invite us to let go of our sense of separation from others and connect with the openness and softness of our hearts.

For additional practice, you can also go to www.shambhala.com/openingtheheart to download a guided audio meditation on the related practice of *tonglen*, a traditional Buddhist meditation to awaken compassion for oneself and others.



Using These Cards

The method I suggest is one that was recommended to me by my teacher Chögyam Trungpa.

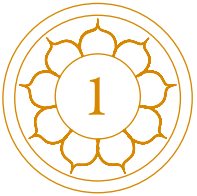
1. Each morning, pick a card at random from the stack.

2. Read a commentary on that slogan. I've offered comments on the reverse side of each card. I also provide additional commentary in the book *Start Where You Are*—and several other useful commentaries on the *lojong* teachings are available, including *Training the Mind and Cultivating Loving-Kindness* by Chögyam Trungpa and *The Great Path of Awakening* by Jamgön Kongtrül (translated by Ken McLeod).

3. Try to live by the meaning of that slogan throughout your day. You might find it helpful to display the day's slogan in your home or workplace using the enclosed card stand.

Sometimes I forget the slogan I've selected for the day, only to be reminded of its message when I come home at night. Usually, however, if something challenging arises, the slogan of the day, or perhaps a different one altogether, will come to mind and provide me with valuable on-the-spot instruction. The slogans always introduce me to a bigger perspective, and I begin to gain confidence that I can use them to become less reactive and see things more clearly throughout my life. Even the most difficult of situations have become more and more workable.

I hope that slogan practice will help you, as it has helped me, to transform all circumstances into the path of enlightenment.



First, train in the preliminaries.

Commentary

The preliminaries are also known as the four reminders.
In your daily life, try to:

1. Maintain an awareness of the preciousness of human life.
2. Be aware of the reality that life ends; death comes for everyone.
3. Recall that whatever you do, whether virtuous or not, has a result; what goes around comes around.
4. Contemplate that as long as you are too focused on self-importance and too caught up in thinking about how you are good or bad, you will suffer. Obsessing about getting what you want and avoiding what you don't want does not result in happiness.



Regard all dharmas as dreams.

Commentary

Whatever you experience in your life—pain, pleasure, heat, cold, or anything else—is like something happening in a dream. Although you might think things are very solid, they are like passing memory. You can experience this open, unfixated quality in sitting meditation; all that arises in your mind—hate, love, and all the rest—is not solid. Although the experience can get extremely vivid, it is just a product of your mind. Nothing solid is really happening.



Examine the nature of unborn awareness.

Commentary

Look at your mind, at just simple awareness itself. “Examine” doesn't mean analyze. It means just looking and seeing if there is anything solid to hold onto. Our mind is constantly shifting and changing. Just look at that!



Self-liberate even the antidote.

Commentary

Do not hang on to anything—even the realization that there's nothing solid to hold onto.



Rest in the nature of alaya, the essence.

Commentary

There is a resting place, a starting place that you can always return to. You can always bring your mind back home and rest right here, right now, in present, unbiased awareness.



In postmeditation, be a child of illusion.

Commentary

When you finish sitting meditation, if things become heavy and solid, be fully present and realize that everything is actually pliable, open, and workable. This is instruction for meditation in action, realizing that you don't have to feel claustrophobic because there is always lots of room, lots of space.



Sending and taking should be practiced alternately.

These two should ride the breath.

Commentary

This is instruction for a meditation practice called *tonglen*. In this practice you send out happiness to others and you take in any suffering that others feel. You take in with a sense of openness and compassion and you send out in the same spirit. People need help, and with this practice we extend ourselves to them.



Three objects, three poisons,
and three seeds of virtue.

Commentary

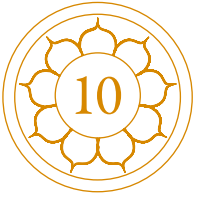
The three objects are: friends, enemies, and neutrals. The three poisons are: craving, aversion, and indifference. When you feel craving, you own it fully and wish that all beings could be free of it. When you feel aggression or indifference you do the same. In this way what usually causes suffering—what poisons us and others—becomes a seed of compassion and loving-kindness, a seed of virtue.



In all activities, train with slogans.

Commentary

Recalling any of these slogans “on the spot” can dissolve our self-centeredness and unkindness.



Begin the sequence of sending
and taking with yourself.

Commentary

Whatever pain you feel, take it in, wishing for all beings to be free of it. Whatever pleasure you feel, send it out to others. In this way, our personal problems and delights become a stepping-stone for understanding the suffering and happiness of all beings.



When the world is filled with evil,
Transform all mishaps into the
path of bodhi.

Commentary

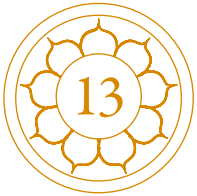
Whatever problems occur in your life, instead of reacting to them in the usual habitual way, you could transform them into the path of the bodhi heart. That is to say, you could awaken your compassionate and open heart. Use the tonglen approach and breathe in the pain of the situation, wishing that all beings could be free of it. Then breathe out and send loving-kindness to all suffering beings, including yourself!



Drive all blames into one.

Commentary

This is advice on how to work with your fellow beings. Everyone is looking for someone to blame and therefore aggression and neurosis keep expanding. Instead, pause and look at what's happening with you. When you hold on so tightly to your view of what they did, you get hooked. Your own self-righteousness causes you to get all worked up and to suffer. So work on cooling that reactivity rather than escalating it. This approach reduces suffering—yours and everyone else's.



Be grateful to everyone.

Commentary

Others will always show you exactly where you are stuck. They say or do something and you automatically get hooked into a familiar way of reacting—shutting down, speeding up, or getting all worked up. When you react in the habitual way, with anger, greed, and so forth, it gives you a chance to see your patterns and work with them honestly and compassionately. Without others provoking you, you remain ignorant of your painful habits and cannot train in transforming them into the path of awakening.



Seeing confusion as the four kayas
Is unsurpassable shunyata
protection.

Commentary

Through meditation practice you begin to realize that:

1. Your thoughts have no birthplace, they just pop up out of nowhere—that is called *dharmakaya.*
2. Thoughts are nevertheless unceasing—this is *sambhogakaya*.
3. They appear but are not solid—that is *nirmanakaya*.
4. Putting that all together, there is no birth, no dwelling, no cessation—this is *svabhavikakaya.*

This understanding gives the unsurpassable protection of realizing what is called *shunyata* or complete openness. There's nothing solid to react to. You have made much ado about nothing!



Four practices are the best of methods.

Commentary

The four practices are:

1. *accumulating merit* through any actions or words that lessen self-absorption and thus create more space in your mind and heart,
2. *laying down evil deeds* through honest and joyful self-reflection,
3. *offering to the döns** by welcoming mishaps because they wake you up, and
4. *offering to the dharmapalas*† by expressing your gratitude to those who protect the teachings that help you and your fellow beings to wake up.

* A *dön* is a sudden wake-up call. Everything is going smoothly and suddenly something shocking happens.

† The *dharmapalas* are the protectors. They represent our basic awareness and manifest as outer situations that bring us back when we stray into unkindness and confusion of all kinds.



Whatever you meet unexpectedly,
join with meditation.

Commentary

The unexpected will stop your mind. Rest in that space. When thoughts start again, do *tonglen*, breathing in whatever pain you may feel, thinking that others also feel like this and gradually becoming more and more willing to feel this pain with the wish that others won't have to suffer. If it is a "good" shock, send out any joy you may feel, wishing for others to feel it also. Meeting the unexpected is also an opportunity to practice patience and nonaggression.



Practice the five strengths,
The condensed heart instructions.

Commentary

The five strengths are:

1. *strong determination* to train in opening the heart and mind;
2. *familiarization* with the practices (such as *tonglen*) that help you to do that;
3. *the positive seed* that is within you, experienced as a yearning to practice and wake up;
4. *reproach*, which is a tricky one for Western students but is an important practice: realizing that ego-clinging causes you to suffer, you delight in self-reflection, honesty, and in seeing where you get stuck; and
5. the *aspiration* to help alleviate suffering in this world, expressing that intention to yourself.



The mahayana instruction for
ejection of consciousness at death

Is the five strengths: how you
conduct yourself is important.

Commentary

When you are dying, practice the five strengths (based on becoming very familiar with them while you are alive).

1. *Strong determination*: Open and let go when the appearances of this world start to dissolve.
2. *Familiarization*: Practice opening and letting go throughout your life so you will not panic as everything dissolves at death.
3. *The positive seed*: Trust that you have the innate ability to let go and to feel compassion for others.
4. *Reproach*: Realizing that this limited identity isn't solid and is dissolving, do not indulge in trying to keep it from falling apart.
5. *Aspiration*: At death, aspire to spend all your future lives in the presence of your teachers and to do your best to benefit others forever.



All dharma agrees at one point.

Commentary

The entire Buddhist teachings (dharma) are about lessening one's self absorption, one's ego-clinging. This is what brings happiness to you and all beings.



Of the two witnesses, hold the principal one.

Commentary

The two witnesses of what you do are others and yourself. Of these two, you are the only one who really knows exactly what is going on. So work with seeing yourself with compassion but without any self-deception.